IT4 Development

Las Vegas Destination

Create information about hidden gems

Popular tourist destinations like cities can get international attention for major attractions like casinos, resorts, or entertainment venues around “downtown” areas. Las Vegas is one of these cities that many think of for its worldwide attractions on The Strip, but there are many hidden local gems located off the Strip. For this assignment, I used Google Maps to create a tourism map that highlights a few of Las Vegas’ “hidden gems.” Stops on my map include Red Rock Canyon National Conservation Area, Las Vegas Arts District (18b), Downtown Container Park, Springs Preserve, Ferguson’s Downtown, Neon Museum Boneyard, and locally owned cafés and restaurants. I also added stops that feature outdoor and cultural views of Las Vegas like Lone Mountain Trail, Floyd Lamb Park at Tule Springs, and Tivoli Village. These stops provide a less resort-heavy view of what the Las Vegas area has to offer.

Google Maps allows travelers to see a custom set of destinations on a map they are already familiar with using when they travel. With pins, descriptions, and pictures added by users, visitors can quickly see where attractions are located and plan a route between them to get to each stop. User-generated tourism information allows visitors to venture outside of the commercialized tourist traps and explore neighborhoods, city parks, and locally owned small businesses. Information technologies that allow users to generate and share information about destinations democratize the power tourists have to shape a destination and can help microentrepreneurs gain more exposure to visitors (Scheyvens & Biddulph, 2018). Sharing this map with visitors or posting it on social media could help promote these businesses and distribute tourism related spending more evenly across the destination.

Give locals’ approval of genuine businesses

The second activity I completed was browsing through Google Maps and reading reviews left by other Google Local Guides about locally owned businesses and attractions in my area. These days many travelers don’t look at conventional marketing from tourism companies to decide where they should go and visit. Many travelers instead rely on user-generated content (UGC) such as reviews, pictures, and star ratings left by other travelers. I decided to look at some businesses and attractions that were frequently recommended by Local Guides that are located in downtown Las Vegas areas like the Las Vegas Arts District, Fremont East District, as well as other attractions and restaurants in neighborhoods away from the Las Vegas Strip. There were numerous small local restaurants, coffee shops, tiny retail shops, and local attractions that appealed to me.

Reviews from Local Guides allow visitors to hear about these local spots from others who have been there. When reading the reviews, travelers are able to see photos, read descriptions, and learn about the good that these locally owned businesses offer. This information can encourage

visitors to stray away from visiting only big corporate businesses and visit some local spots that really help the city out. Studies have found that UGC strongly influences travelers' decision-making (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). This is because tourists are more likely to trust the reviews that they're reading over company advertisements. This activity shows businesses that get high reviews and support from people familiar with the area.

Market tourism services

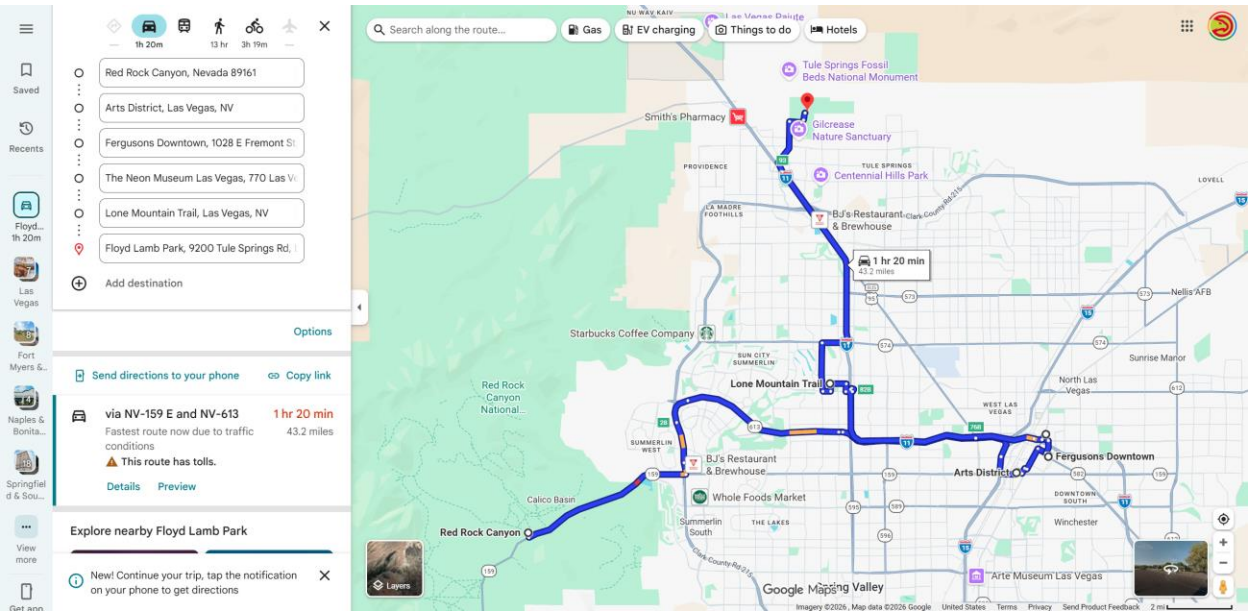
The final activity had us going through the steps of making a lodging listing on Airbnb. I went through all of the steps it would take to list a lodging on Airbnb. This included choosing your type of property, uploading photos, writing a description, marking amenities, and naming your nightly price. The listing that I created was for a locally owned property located near the Las Vegas Arts District. The Arts District in Las Vegas is known for its locally owned restaurants, galleries, and attractions.

Platforms such as Airbnb have lowered many of the barriers which have previously stopped locals from taking part in tourism directly. By using online platforms, locals are now able to advertise their lodging, tours, or other services to tourists without going through a hospitality corporation. By taking part in the "sharing economy", potential tourism microentrepreneurs are able to make money and provide visitors with an authentic experience. The sharing economy has broadened micro-participation in tourism and the capacity for locals to influence tourism development (Guttentag, 2015).

Appendix

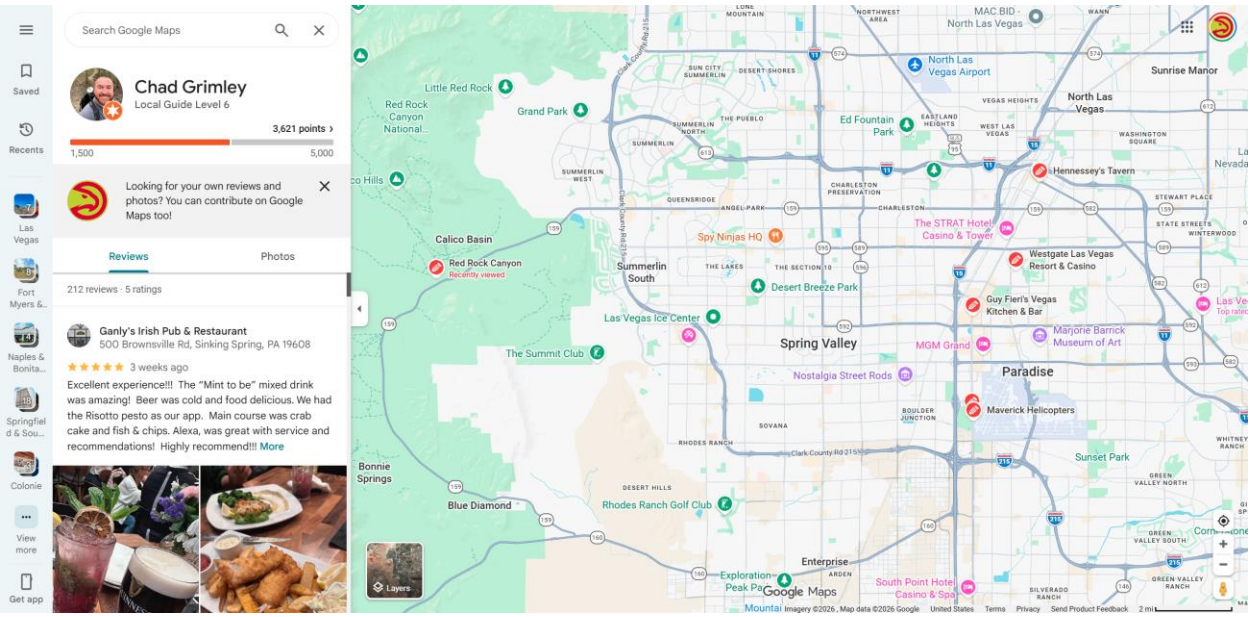
Part 1: Google Maps Hidden Gems Map

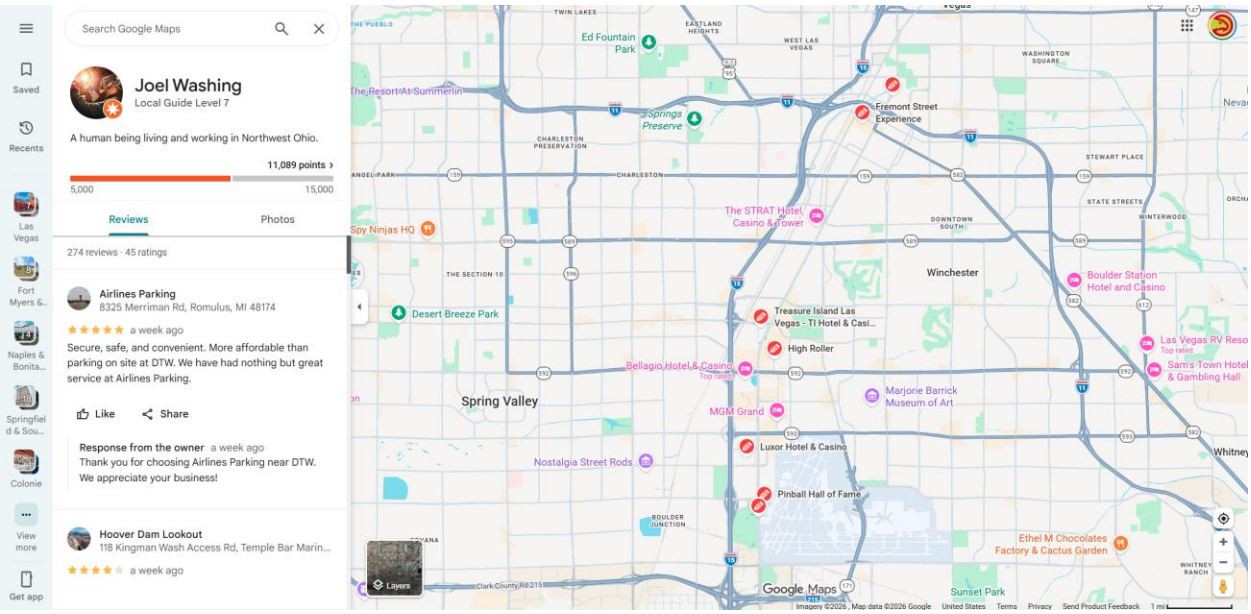
The screenshots below document the tourism themed Google Maps custom map created to feature hidden gem location pins and descriptions in Las Vegas. Locations featured include Red Rock Canyon, Las Vegas Arts District, Ferguson's Downtown, Neon Museum, Lone Mountain Trail, and Floyd Lamb Park. These locations were chosen because they featured unique culture, outdoor recreation, or locally owned businesses off the Strip.



Part 2: Google Local Guide Reviews

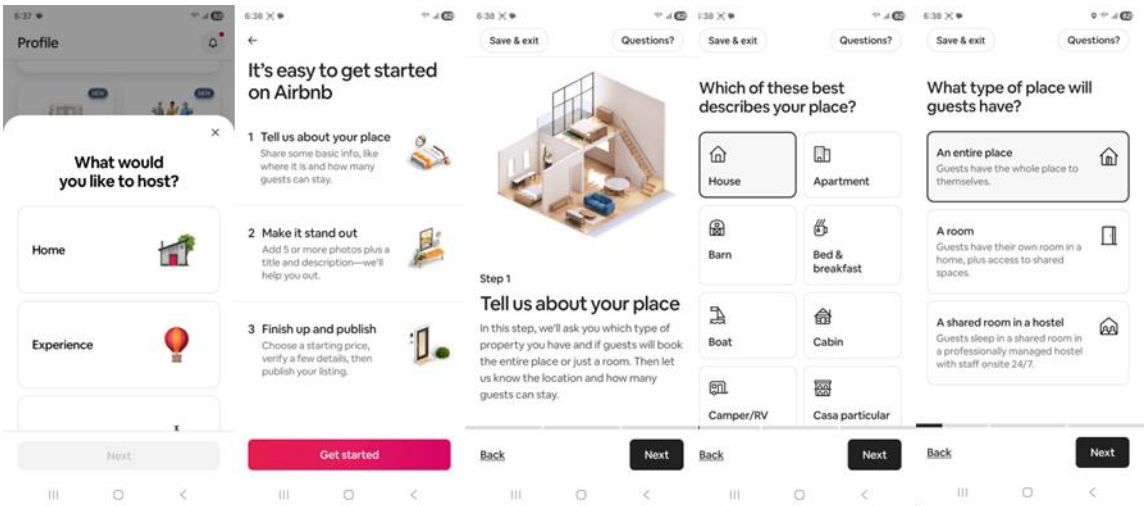
The screenshots below display examples of Google Local Guide reviews, photos, and ratings of locally owned businesses and attractions that one can visit in Las Vegas. These reviews demonstrate where to find authentic places to visit outside of the large resorts and which businesses have large local support.

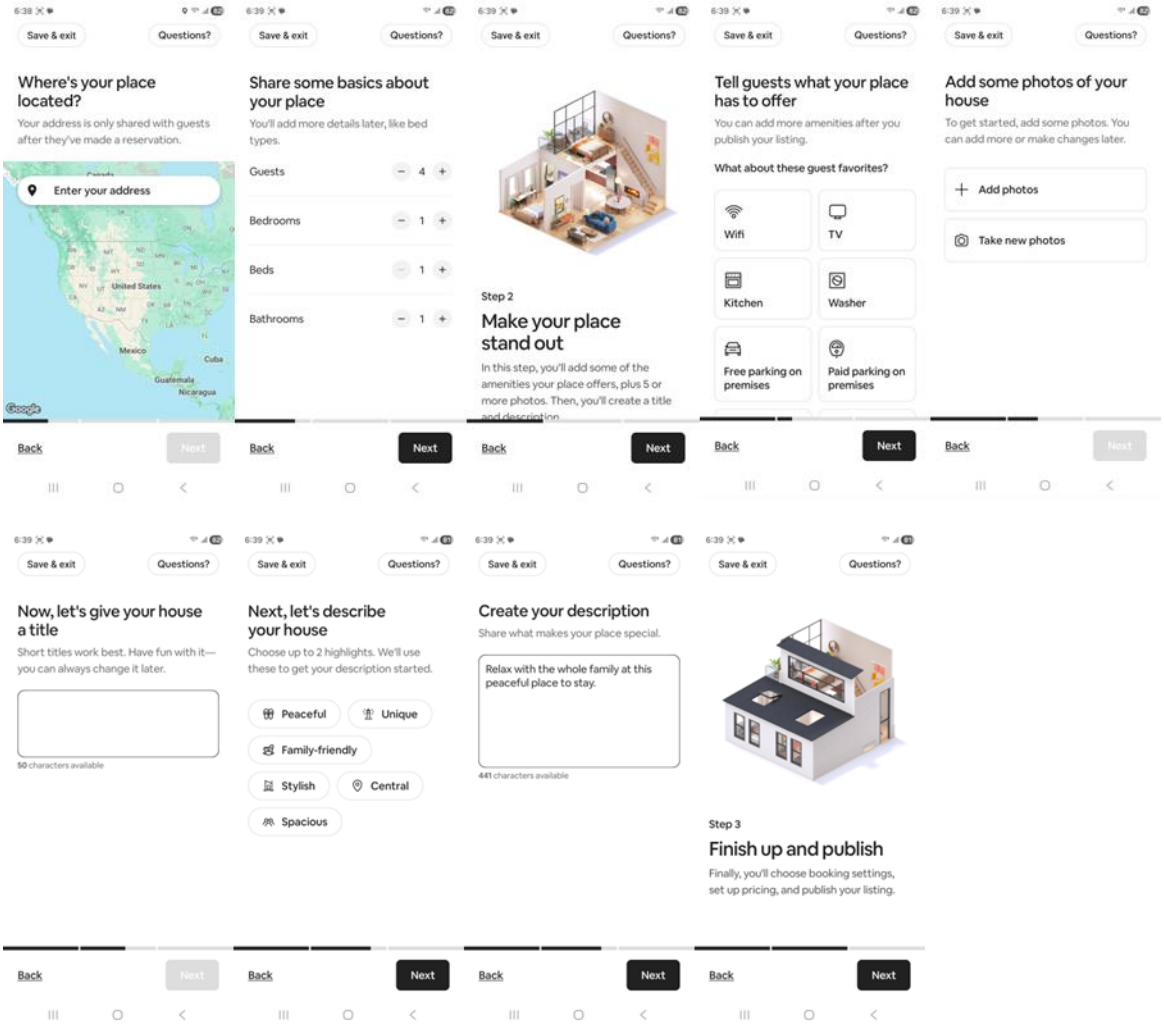




Part 3: Airbnb Lodging Listing

The screenshots below display the steps I took to create a sample Airbnb listing for a locally owned property near the Las Vegas Arts district. This included choosing the type of property being listed, uploading photos, entering a description, and entering a price per night.





References

Guttentag, D. (2015). Airbnb: Disruptive innovation and the rise of an informal tourism accommodation sector. Current Issues in Tourism, 18(12), 1192–1217. https://doi.org/10.1080/13683500.2013.827159

Scheyvens, R., & Biddulph, R. (2018). Inclusive tourism development. Tourism Geographies, 20(4), 589–609. https://doi.org/10.1080/14616688.2017.1381985

Xiang, Z., & Gretzel, U. (2010). Role of social media in online travel information search. Tourism Management, 31(2), 179–188. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tourman.2009.02.016